the ground fire that comes up." His other option was to respond on the next day with a general strike against all military targets in Cuba.

When the news of antiaircraft fire first arrived, Bundy reminded everyone that the Cubans had issued a warning about starting to shoot at American airplanes. But what McNamara now proposed was not a strike against Cuban antiaircraft batteries but against Soviet-operated SAM missiles and, potentially, against their other installations, including nuclear-armed ballistic missiles. "I'm rather inclined to take the more general response," Kennedy told his aides. He no longer believed that a strike against a selected antiaircraft battery or missile site would be effective. But he asked for more time to make a final decision. "Do the reconnaissance tomorrow," he told his aides. "If we get fired on, then we meet here and we decide whether to do a much more general [strike]." Kennedy was playing for time, which he needed if he were to attempt a diplomatic solution.[11]

It soon became apparent that he had no time at all. "The U-2 was shot down," said McNamara, interrupting the discussion in the Cabinet Room. Kennedy had just impressed on his aides the need to organize NATO support for the Cuba-Turkey swap as soon as possible. This news was not about Maultsby's plane but about another U-2 overflying Cuba about which they had been informed earlier in the day. "A U-2 was shot down?" asked John Kennedy in disbelief. "Was the pilot killed?" Robert Kennedy asked in turn. "The pilot's body is in the plane," came the answer from General Taylor. He added that the plane had been struck by a surface-to-air missile, which suggested that it had been fired not by the Cubans but by the Soviets.[12]

The U-2 plane on which McNamara reported had been piloted by a thirty-five-year-old veteran of the Korean War, Major Rudolf Anderson. It belonged to the 4028th Strategic Reconnaissance Weather Squadron of the 4080th Strategic Reconnaissance Wing, permanently stationed at Laughlin Air Force Base in Texas. But with the Cuban missile crisis in full swing and the CIA increasing its surveillance overflights, Anderson had been transferred to the East Coast. On the morning of October 27 he took off from McCoy Air Force Base in Orlando, Florida, heading for Cuba. He sent a coded message once he left American airspace and entered Cuban airspace at 10:12 a.m. EST.[13]